

Word family: **agent / agents / agency / agentive**

Base word: agent

Plural: agents

Related forms: agency, agentive

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective-related technical form (相關技術形容詞)

Your sentence:

> "...making up ridiculous stories about being detectives, explorers, or secret **agents**."

Meaning in this passage

Here, **agent** means a **person who works secretly for a government or organization, especially to collect information or carry out confidential missions**.

繁體中文： **秘密替政府或組織工作、蒐集情報或執行機密任務的人；特工 / 秘密情報員**

中文翻譯：

> "...stories about being detectives, explorers, or secret **agents**."

「.....編一些關於自己是偵探、探險家或秘密**特工**的荒誕故事。」

Here:

secret agent = 秘密替政府或組織執行情報或機密任務的人

1. **agent = representative who acts for another person/company (代理人) — 代理人；經紀人；代辦**

Meaning: A person or company authorized to act on behalf of someone else.

Practice 1

> "The actor spoke to her **agent** about the new contract."

「那位演員和她的**經紀人**談了新合約。」

Practice 2

> "Please contact our local **agent** for further information."

「如需更多資料，請聯絡我們的本地**代理人 / 代理商**。」

****agent = 獲授權代表另一個人、公司或組織處理事務的人或機構****

The Chinese depends on domain:

- * actor's agent → 經紀人
- * travel agent → 旅行代理 / 旅行社職員
- * sales agent → 銷售代理
- * insurance agent → 保險代理

These are one broad ****representative**** sense.

2. ****agent = person who arranges business/deals for clients (經紀) — 經紀人****

This is especially common in entertainment, sport, property, and business.

Practice 3

> “Her literary ****agent**** found a publisher for the book.”

「她的文學****經紀人****替那本書找到出版社。」

Practice 4

> “The player’s ****agent**** negotiated the contract.”

「球員的****經紀人****協商了合約。」

****agent = 代表客戶安排工作、合約、交易或其他商業事務的人****

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 1.

The job changes, but the underlying concept remains:

> ****acting on behalf of another party****

3. ****agent = secret/intelligence operative (情報 / 秘密工作) — 特工 ; 情報員****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** A person who secretly gathers information or performs confidential work for a government or organization.

Practice 5 — Original

> “We made up stories about being secret **agents**.”

「我們會編故事，幻想自己是秘密**特工**。」

Practice 6

> “The novel follows an undercover **agent** on a dangerous mission.”

「這本小說講述一名臥底**特工 / 情報員**執行危險任務的故事。」

Practice 7

> “The **agent** was sent abroad to gather information.”

「那名**情報員**被派往海外蒐集情報。」

agent = 秘密替政府或組織蒐集情報、調查或執行機密任務的人

This is distinct enough from an ordinary commercial representative to keep separate.

4. **agent** = official investigator/enforcement officer (執法人員) — 探員；專員

In some official agencies, **agent** is part of the job title for an investigator or enforcement officer.

Practice 8

> “Federal **agents** searched the building.”

「聯邦**探員 / 執法人員**搜查了那棟建築。」

Practice 9

> “An **agent** interviewed several witnesses.”

「一名**探員**訪問了幾名目擊者。」

agent = 受政府機構僱用、負責調查或執法工作的官員

This overlaps historically with “person acting for an organization,” but modern learners encounter it as a recognizable law-enforcement role.

For core counting, I would usually place it near the **official/secret operative** family rather than create a completely separate top-level sense.

5. **agent** = substance that produces an effect (物質 / 科學) — 作用劑；媒介；因子

Agent can also mean a substance, force, organism, or thing that causes a particular effect.

Practice 10

> “Bleach is a powerful cleaning **agent**.”

「漂白水是一種強力的清潔**劑**。」

Practice 11

> “The chemical acts as a binding **agent**.”

「這種化學物質可作為黏合**劑**。」

agent = 能夠引起某種作用、變化或效果的物質、力量或因素

Common:

- * cleaning agent
- * bleaching agent
- * binding agent
- * chemical agent

This is a genuinely different non-human sense.

6. **agent** = cause/factor that brings about change (作用因素) — 因素；推動者

The same idea can extend beyond physical substances.

Practice 12

> “Education can be an **agent of change**.”

「教育可以成為推動改變的**力量 / 因素**。」

Practice 13

> “Technology has acted as an **agent** of social transformation.”

「科技一直是社會轉變的一個重要**推動因素**。」

agent = 促成某種結果、轉變或影響的事物或力量

For core counting, I would merge this with Meaning 5 under:

> **something that produces an effect**

The Manual emphasizes splitting by genuine conceptual change, not merely because one example is chemical and another abstract.

7. **agent** = infectious cause (醫學 / 生物) — 病原體；致病因子

In medicine and biology, an **agent** may be the thing that causes a disease.

Practice 14

> “The researchers identified the infectious **agent**.”

「研究人員找出了該疾病的**病原體 / 致病因子**。」

Practice 15

> “The disease can be caused by several different **agents**.”

「這種疾病可能由幾種不同的**致病因子**引起。」

agent = 能夠引起疾病、感染或生物反應的病原體或因素

This is a useful domain extension of Meaning 5, not a separate core sense.

Related form: **agency**

Agency has several important meanings.

agency = organization that provides a service (機構 / 代理公司) — 代理機構；服務機構

Practice 16

> “She works for an advertising **agency**.”

「她在一間廣告**公司 / 代理機構**工作。」

Practice 17

> “We booked the holiday through a travel **agency**.”

「我們透過旅行**社 / 代理機構**預訂假期。」

agency = 代表客戶提供專業服務、代理或安排事務的機構

agency = government organization (政府機構) — 機關 ; 機構

Practice 18

> “The environmental **agency** published a new report.”

「環境**機構 / 部門**發表了一份新報告。」

Practice 19

> “Several public **agencies** worked together.”

「幾個公共**機構**共同合作。」

agency = 負責某一特定職能的政府或公共機構

agency = ability to act independently (抽象概念) — 行動自主性 ; 能動性

In psychology, sociology, philosophy, and related fields, **agency** can mean the capacity to make choices and act independently.

Practice 20

> “The character gradually gains more **agency**.”

「這個角色逐漸獲得更多**自主行動能力 / 能動性**。」

Practice 21

> “Students need a sense of **agency** in their own learning.”

「學生在自己的學習過程中需要有一種**自主掌控感**。」

****agency = 個人能夠自主作決定並採取行動、影響結果的能力****

This is a useful but more academic extension.

Related form: ****agentive****

****Agentive**** is a technical adjective, especially in linguistics.

It means relating to the entity that intentionally performs an action.

Practice 22

> “The sentence gives the subject an ****agentive**** role.”

「這個句子讓主語具有****施事者****角色。」

****agentive = 與主動執行某項動作的施事者有關的****

This is specialist vocabulary, so I would keep it as a low-priority family note rather than core learner material.

The Golden Manual says specialist forms may be included when useful, but low-frequency technical material should not be overpromoted.

Important distinction: ****agent vs representative****

****agent****

often implies formal authorization to act for another person or organization.

****representative****

is broader and can simply mean someone who speaks or appears on behalf of a group.

> sales agent

> company representative

They may overlap, but ****agent**** often has a stronger business/legal sense of acting for a principal.

Important distinction: **agent vs broker**

agent

acts on behalf of a client.

broker

typically brings buyers and sellers together or arranges transactions.

Depending on the industry, the roles can overlap, but they are not automatically identical.

Important distinction: **agent vs spy**

secret agent

is a broad term for someone secretly working for a government or organization.

spy

specifically emphasizes secretly gathering information, especially about another country or organization.

A secret agent may perform tasks beyond intelligence gathering, whereas **spy** foregrounds espionage.

Important distinction: **agent vs detective**

This is especially useful for your passage.

detective

investigates crimes or mysteries.

agent

may represent an organization, enforce laws, or conduct secret/intelligence work.

So in:

> “detectives, explorers, or secret agents”

the three roles are deliberately different.

Important distinction: **agent** vs **agency**

agent

= the person or entity acting

agency

= often the organization they work for, or the abstract ability to act

> travel agent = 旅行代理 / 職員

> travel agency = 旅行社

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **agent**

* **agents**

* **agency**

Lower-priority technical extension:

* **agentive**

Useful compounds include:

* secret agent

* travel agent

* estate agent

* insurance agent

* literary agent

* sales agent

* cleaning agent

* infectious agent

* agent of change

The Golden Manual requires a broad family sweep across derivations, compounds, idioms, and modern specialist uses, while filtering out material that is too obscure for practical learner use.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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agent — representative	獲授權代表另一個人、公司或組織處理事務的人或機構
agent — secret/intelligence operative	秘密替政府或組織蒐集情報、調查或執行機密任務的人
agent — investigator/enforcement officer	受官方機構僱用、負責調查或執法工作的官員；與 official-operative 義相關
agent — substance/cause	能夠引起某種作用、變化、疾病或結果的物質、因素或力量
agency — service organization	提供代理、安排或專業服務的機構
agency — public body	負責某一特定職能的政府或公共機構
agency — autonomous capacity	個人能夠自主作決定、採取行動並影響結果的能力
agentive	與主動執行動作的施事者有關的；技術用語

For your original sentence

> “...being detectives, explorers, or secret **agents**.”

The exact meaning is:

****agent = 秘密替政府或組織工作、蒐集情報或執行機密任務的人****

So:

> ****secret agent****

= ****秘密特工 / 情報員****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****agent****:

1. ****a representative who acts on behalf of another person or organization****
2. ****a secret/official operative, investigator, or intelligence officer****
3. ****a substance, factor, organism, or force that produces an effect****

I would merge ****literary agent / sports agent / travel agent / sales agent**** under #1, merge official investigative uses near #2, and merge ****cleaning agent / infectious agent / agent of change**** under #3 rather than inflate the core count.